Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Billy Collins's "Introduction to Poetry"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of Billy Collins's "Introduction to Poetry" that focuses on the strength of the speaker's (the teacher's) several comparisons in his argument against traditional explication include

auditory imagery,
tactile imagery,
visual imagery,
metaphor,
metonymy,
sigmatism,
simile,
speaker,
synecdoche,
tenor,
tone, and
vehicle.

The contestant should note the embodied experiential that defines the level of engagement to which the speaker's imagery draws his audience, his students: the first stanza's visual imagery; the auditory imagery upon which line four depends; and then the tactile imagery associated with the two verbs "probe" (line 6) and "feel" (line 8). The writer's focus should reckon with the contrast that begins with line 9's "I want them to waterski." The speaker' speaking to "the surface of a poem" (line 10) offers the writer a *point de départ* for contrasting the speaker's approach to the approach that his students have trained to take in the explication of poetry, an approach that the speaker compares to enervating torture.

The speaker's tactile imagery strikes a different emphasis in the poem's final two stanzas—in distinct contrast to the searching blindness dependent upon probing through a maze and feeling through a dark space in search of, in this case, an understanding of the poem.

Some discussion of the metaphors, their vehicles and their tenors, would enhance the essay, as would some probing regarding the metonymic or synecdochic imagery of a hive (line 4) upon which the busy-ness of the poem's internal activity—the traditional "target" of explication—seemingly depends.

A contestant might recall Wordsworth's condemnation "we murder to dissect" in analyzing Collins's disdain for what the contest asks our students to do.